Enhancing Wellbeing in Jordan - Analytical Report

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Executive Summary

This report presents a comprehensive analysis of subjective well-being in Jordan, commissioned by the Ministry of Health. Based on a survey of over 1000 participants, the study investigates the intersection of mental health, food security, socioeconomic factors, and lifestyle behaviors.

Key findings highlight the critical role of individual attributes alongside structural factors. **Physical activity** was found to exert a "dosage effect" on mental health; while moderate exercise boosts resilience, frequent activity is required to positively shift one's stress mindset. A notable **gender gap** was also identified, with males exhibiting a significantly stronger tendency to view stress as a positive challenge compared to females.

Regarding the youth, **university students represent a vulnerable demographic**, exhibiting significantly higher levels of psychological distress compared to the general population, despite possessing comparable resilience. Economically, a dual reality emerged: higher income predicts **healthy dietary habits** but does not linearly reduce unhealthy consumption, suggesting fast-food intake is behaviorally driven. Furthermore, a critical link was established between **academic performance** and basic needs; students with higher GPAs reported significantly lower food insecurity, highlighting that academic success is intrinsically tied to nutritional stability.

The report concludes with actionable recommendations, emphasizing the need for gender-sensitive mental health support, university-based interventions, and targeted nutritional programs to enhance the overall well-being of the Jordanian society.

Introduction

The Ministry of Health in Jordan recognizes that well-being extends beyond the absence of disease to include mental resilience, food security, and healthy lifestyle choices. This analytical report serves as a strategic document to interpret the findings of the **Subjective Wellbeing Questionnaire (SWQ)**. By examining data from a diverse sample of the population, we aim to move beyond descriptive statistics to understand the *drivers* of well-being.

This report focuses on identifying risk factors and protective mechanisms. It specifically explores how enrollment in higher education impacts mental health, the influence of lifestyle behaviors—such as physical activity—on psychological resilience, and the demographic nuances of stress perception. Furthermore, it investigates how economic disparities shape dietary patterns and how food security correlates with academic

achievement. The insights provided herein are intended to guide the Ministry in formulating evidence-based policies that foster a supportive environment for all citizens, with a special focus on the youth and student population.

Discussion

This section interprets the statistical findings within the broader socioeconomic and behavioral context of Jordan, highlighting **five critical themes** that emerged from the analysis. These themes bridge the gap between structural determinants, such as income, food security, and academic pressure, and individual attributes like gender, physical activity, and mindset. Together, they offer a holistic and multi-dimensional view of the factors driving well-being in the population.

1. The Dosage Effect: Physical Activity as a Scalable Mental Shield

The analysis uncovered a critical dosage effect regarding the impact of physical activity on mental well-being. While moderate exercise (2 times/week) was found sufficient to create a statistically significant improvement in resilience (BRS), shifting one's fundamental *mindset* towards stress (SMM) required a much higher commitment (4 times/week or more). This distinction suggests that physical activity functions as a tiered psychological intervention. Simply moving the body acts as an immediate buffer, helping individuals bounce back from daily stressors (Resilience). However, fostering a stress-is-enhancing mentality (where an individual actively views pressure as a tool for growth) requires the discipline and physiological adaptation associated with a frequent, active lifestyle. Thus, exercise is not just a physical tool, but a graduated mental health strategy.

2. The Gender Gap in Stress Perception: Challenge vs. Threat

The statistical analysis revealed a significant gender disparity in how stress is processed, with male participants reporting significantly higher Stress Mindset (SMM) scores compared to females. This indicates that males are more inclined to adopt a stress-is-enhancing perspective, viewing high-pressure situations as challenges to be overcome rather than threats to be avoided. This gap may be rooted in differing social conditioning or biological responses to stress. For policymakers and health officials, this highlights that mental health support cannot be "one-size-fits-all"; females might benefit more from cognitive reframing interventions to help shift their perspective on stress, while males might need support in acknowledging when stress crosses the line into burnout.

3. The Student Wellbeing Paradox High Distress, Normal Resilience

The analysis revealed a concerning disparity in mental health: university students exhibited significantly higher levels of psychological distress (K10 scores) compared to the non-student population. However, interestingly, there was no significant difference in their resilience levels (RS scores).

This phenomenon suggests a **"Situational Overload"** rather than an inherent psychological deficit. Students possess the same capacity to bounce back from stress as the general public, but they are currently operating in a high-pressure environment characterized by academic demands, financial instability, and future career anxiety. The high distress scores indicate that their resilience (while normal) are being overwhelmed by the sheer volume of stressors they face daily. This distinguishes the student population as a group in need of *supportive systems* to reduce load, rather than just *corrective interventions* to fix resilience.

4. The Economics of Nutrition: Affordability vs. Lifestyle

The relationship between household income and dietary habits unveiled a dual reality. On one hand, income is a powerful driver of **Healthy Eating**. The strong positive linear trend confirms that access to nutrient-dense foods (fruits, vegetables, proteins) is largely an economic privilege; as purchasing power rises, so does the quality of the diet.

On the other hand, income failed to predict **Unhealthy Eating** (fast food/caffeine) in a linear fashion. This indicates that the consumption of unhealthy food is less about *affordability* and more about *lifestyle and convenience*. Fast food consumption appears to be a behavioral norm that cuts across class lines—consumed by the lower-income groups possibly due to cheap availability, and by middle-to-high income groups likely due to time constraints and social habits. This implies that economic subsidies alone may improve healthy intake but will not necessarily curb unhealthy consumption without behavioral awareness campaigns.

5. Barriers to Achievement: The Invisible Cost of Food Insecurity

Perhaps the most critical finding for policy planning is the inverse linear relationship between **Food Insecurity (FIES)** and **Academic Performance (GPA)**. Students with the highest food insecurity scores consistently reported lower GPAs.

This correlation underscores a physiological barrier to education: hunger and nutritional anxiety compromise cognitive function, concentration, and energy levels. It is unrealistic to expect optimal academic output from students who are struggling

to secure their next meal. This finding reframes food security not just as a welfare issue, but as an **educational equity issue**. Ensuring food stability for students is, therefore, a direct investment in the country's human capital and future workforce quality.

Recommendations and Further Work

Based on the key findings of this analysis, the following strategic recommendations are proposed to the Ministry of Health to enhance the subjective well-being of the population, with a specific focus on youth and students:

1. **Recommendations**

- **Integrate "Exercise as Medicine":** Recognizing the "dosage effect" of physical activity, public health initiatives should promote exercise not just for physical fitness but as a mental health tool.
    - **For Mindset Shift:** Develop intensive sports programs (4 times/week) within universities and workplaces to help individuals build the discipline required to view stress as a challenge rather than a threat.
- **Adopt Gender-Responsive Mental Health Strategies:** Since males and females perceive stress differently, interventions should be tailored.
    - **For Females**: Focus on cognitive-behavioral workshops that help reframe stress from a "threat" to a "challenge" to boost their Stress Mindset scores.
    - **For Males:** While they view stress positively, they may be at risk of burnout. Programs should focus on "sustainable performance" and recognizing emotional limits.
- **Implement "Hunger-Free Campus" Initiatives:** Given the strong link between food security and academic performance (GPA), universities should introduce subsidized meal programs or food vouchers for students. Ensuring affordable access to nutritious food on campus is a direct intervention to support both physical health and academic success.
- **Establish Proactive Student Wellness Centers:** Since students exhibit high distress but normal resilience, the issue is not a lack of coping skills but an overload of stressors. Universities should expand mental health services to focus on "Decompression Spaces" and stress management workshops, rather than just

crisis intervention, to help students manage the unique pressures of university life.

- **Targeted Nutrition Campaigns:**
  - **Economic Support:** To promote healthy eating, policy efforts should focus on subsidizing fresh produce (fruits/vegetables) to make them accessible to lower-income households.
  - **Behavioral Change:** To curb unhealthy eating, which is not driven by income, public health campaigns must focus on behavioral change and awareness regarding the risks of fast food and excessive caffeine, targeting all socioeconomic classes.

2. Further Work

To advance this analysis to the next level, the following steps are suggested:

- **For "Exercise as Medicine": Comparative Activity Study**
  - **Action:** Conduct a study to investigate if the "dosage effect" varies by the *type* of physical activity (e.g., team sports vs. solitary gym sessions).
  - **Why?** While we know frequency matters, understanding which specific activities best boost resilience will allow for more precise public health prescriptions.
- **For Gender-Responsive Strategies: Intervention Efficacy Testing**
  - **Action:** Launch a pilot program for the proposed gender-specific workshops on a small scale and measure pre- and post-intervention SMM scores.
  - **Why?** This validates whether cognitive reframing techniques effectively improve Stress Mindset in females before allocating resources for a national rollout.
- **For "Hunger-Free Campus": Impact Assessment**
  - **Action:** Implement a tracking system within universities to correlate the usage of food vouchers with students' subsequent semester GPA.
  - **Why?** This will provide empirical evidence on the Return on Investment (ROI) of food subsidies, proving that nutrition is a cost-effective academic intervention.

- **For Student Wellness Centers: Root Cause Analysis**
    - **Action:** Conduct qualitative focus groups to identify the specific stressors overwhelming students (e.g., is it financial debt, exam pressure, or social expectations?).
    - **Why?** "Decompression Spaces" are most effective when designed to counter specific stressors. Knowing the root causes ensures these centers are not just generic quiet rooms, but targeted solutions.
- **For Targeted Nutrition Campaigns: Behavioral Drivers Study**
    - **Action:** Commission a behavioral economics study to understand *why* high-income individuals continue to consume unhealthy food despite having the means to eat healthily.
    - **Why?** Understanding the psychological drivers (e.g., convenience, marketing, taste) is crucial to designing effective awareness campaigns that go beyond simple affordability.